

What is Saul to Us?

Chris Oswald · Providence Community Church, Lenexa, KS · October 4, 2026

1 Samuel 8:1-

31:13

PRIMARY TEXT

38 min

SERMON LENGTH

30

SCRIPTURE
REFERENCES

30

SECTIONS WE MAPPED

THE SERMON IN ONE SENTENCE

Trials, not spiritual experiences or good works, reveal the tested genuineness of our faith by showing whether we love God for himself or merely use him to get what we want.

Summary

This sermon uses the life of King Saul as a diagnostic tool to examine the difference between genuine faith and religious pragmatism. Saul looked like a genuine believer — the Spirit rushed upon him, God gave him another heart, he had good works and spiritual experiences — yet his life ended in catastrophic apostasy, consulting a witch and falling on his sword under divine curse. The sermon argues that neither spiritual experiences, good works, nor seeking God's blessings can distinguish real faith from false. Only trials reveal genuine faith by showing whether we love God for himself or merely use him to get what we want. When pressured, Saul consistently chose disobedience over trust, proving his transactional heart. The pastoral application calls those who have endured trials to recognize God's gift of assurance, warns comfort-seekers to embrace hard things, and offers evangelistic hope: just as Saul of Tarsus was transformed by grace into the apostle Paul, any religious hypocrite can be genuinely saved today.

YOUR SERMON PAGE

<https://sermonsteward.com/ProvidenceLenexa/sermons/what-is-saul-to-us-2026-10-04>

THIS WEEK ACROSS THE REGION

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/MidwestNorthwest/10-4-26/>

Eight Sovereign Grace churches, one Sunday: Scripture, themes, and How We Said It.

What We Noticed

Doctrinal loci

- **Soteriology** — The sermon's central concern is distinguishing genuine saving faith from false profession, engaging assurance, election, and the nature of conversion through the Saul case study.
- **Sanctification** — The sermon examines how trials function as God's ordained means of revealing and refining genuine faith, teaching perseverance as evidence of regeneration.
- **Pneumatology** — The sermon carefully distinguishes between the Spirit's temporary empowering of Saul and genuine regeneration, using Hebrews 6 and Calvin to show the Spirit can operate without indwelling.
- **Ecclesiology** — The sermon addresses the presence of false professors in the visible church and applies Israel's institutional apostasy as warning for contemporary church bodies.

Themes

Genuine faith versus religious pragmatism

Trials as the test of authentic Christianity

The danger of transactional relationship with God

Assurance through perseverance under pressure

Hope for transformation of religious hypocrites

Editor notes

- The sermon's use of onomastics — the names Samuel ('God is heard') and Saul ('you asked for it') as a theological joke — is a memorable hermeneutical move that carries weight throughout the exposition.
- The Calvin and Owen quotations do heavy theological lifting, providing Reformed authority for the controversial claim that the Spirit can grant experiences to the non-elect without regenerating them.
- The papier-mâché car repair illustration perfectly captures the sermon's thesis about trials exposing false construction, and it's self-deprecating enough to land with warmth rather than condemnation.
- The redemptive-historical payoff connecting Old Testament Saul to Saul of Tarsus transformed into Paul is the sermon's strongest evangelistic move, offering hope without softening the diagnostic edge.

Writing Prompts

Concepts from each main point you could explore further in your own reading and writing.

1. When God Says 'You Asked For It': What the Name Saul Tells Us About Getting What We Want

The Hebrew wordplay between Samuel ('God is heard') and Saul ('you asked for it') reveals a pattern throughout Scripture: God sometimes gives us what we demand as a form of judgment. The article would explore how to discern faithful petition from faithless demand, using Israel's panic in 1 Samuel 8 as the test case.

FROM: MOVEMENT UNIT [2], THE ONOMASTIC THEOLOGICAL CLAIM ABOUT THE MEANING EMBEDDED IN SAUL'S NAME

2. The King Who Used God: Understanding Transactional Religion

Saul treated Yahweh the way pagan kings treated their deities — as a cosmic vending machine to dispense blessings for proper religious deposits. This article would define transactional religion, show how it differs from legitimate promise-motivated obedience, and help readers identify it in their own hearts.

FROM: MOVEMENT UNIT [3], THE DEFINITION OF 'A KING LIKE ALL THE OTHER NATIONS' AS TRANSACTIONAL RELIGIOSITY

3. Can You Taste the Holy Spirit and Still Go to Hell? What Hebrews 6 Teaches About Spiritual Experience

Hebrews 6:4-6 describes people who were 'enlightened' and 'tasted the heavenly gift' and 'shared in the Holy Spirit' — yet fell away. Drawing on Calvin and Owen, this article would explain how the Spirit can powerfully operate on someone without regenerating them, and why spiritual experiences cannot serve as the ultimate test of genuine conversion.

FROM: MOVEMENT UNITS [16-17], THE THEOLOGICAL RESOLUTION OF HOW NON-ELECT PEOPLE CAN HAVE GENUINE SPIRITUAL EXPERIENCES

4. The One Test That Reveals Real Faith: Why Trials Matter More Than Spiritual Experiences

If neither spiritual highs, good works, nor seeking God's blessings can distinguish real faith from false, what can? The article would develop the thesis that trials — moments when obedience is costly and God's ways make no sense — are the God-given crucible that reveals whether we love the Giver or just want the gifts, using both Saul's failures and 1 Peter 1:6-7.

FROM: MOVEMENT UNIT [19], THE SERMON'S MAIN THESIS ABOUT TRIALS TESTING GENUINENESS

5. Stop Running From Hard Things: Why American Christians Need to Embrace Trials

Our culture's obsession with comfort and avoidance of difficulty makes us spiritually weaker, not stronger. This article would make the case that Christians should stop engineering lives of ease and instead recognize hard trials as 'uniquely valuable' for revealing God and ourselves, challenging the therapeutic gospel that dominates American evangelicalism.

FROM: MOVEMENT UNIT [23], THE APPLICATION CALLING THOSE WITHOUT IDENTIFIED TRIALS TO STOP AVOIDING HARD THINGS

6. How to Know Your Faith Is Real: Finding Assurance in Past Obedience Under Pressure

Many Christians struggle with assurance of salvation, looking for validation in conversion experiences or emotional certainty. This pastoral article would teach readers to look instead at moments when staying faithful was costly — surprise pregnancies, unwanted singleness, financial loss, caring for aging parents — and they chose obedience anyway, recognizing these as God's gift of evidence.

FROM: MOVEMENT UNITS [21-22], THE PASTORAL APPLICATION OFFERING ASSURANCE THROUGH PERSEVERANCE IN SPECIFIC TRIALS

7. The Haunted House Church: When Institutions Keep the Form but Lose the Spirit

By Isaiah's time, Israel had become corporately what Saul was individually — externally religious but spiritually dead. This article would explore institutional apostasy, how churches and denominations can maintain orthodox structures while being inhabited by a wrong spirit, and what faithful remnants should do when they find themselves in such contexts.

FROM: MOVEMENT UNIT [24], THE INSTITUTIONAL APPLICATION COMPARING ISRAEL IN ISAIAH TO SAUL

8. From Hypocrite to Apostle: The Hope That Even a Saul Can Become a Paul

Saul of Tarsus was a New Testament recapitulation of King Saul — religious, zealous, persecuting God's anointed — yet grace transformed him into Paul, the foremost example of God's mercy to sinners. This evangelistic article would offer hope to those who recognize themselves as empty religious performers, showing that transformation is possible and conversion can happen today.

FROM: MOVEMENT UNITS [25-26], THE REDEMPTIVE-HISTORICAL CLIMAX AND PAUL'S TESTIMONY FROM 1 TIMOTHY 1

Congregation Resources

The same resources published on your sermon page.

Small-Group Discussion

Saul began his reign with dramatic spiritual experiences—the Spirit of God came upon him, he prophesied with the prophets, God gave him a new heart. Yet the sermon argues these experiences did not indicate genuine faith. What does this tell us about how we often evaluate whether someone's faith is real, either in others or in ourselves?

- ↳ Can you think of a time when you assumed someone's faith was genuine based on their spiritual experiences or religious activity, only to discover later that something was missing underneath?

1 SAMUEL 10:6-11; HEBREWS 6:4-6

The sermon says that Saul's request for a king 'like all the other nations' represents a fundamentally transactional view of God—using religion to get what he wants rather than trusting God's actual provision. Where do you see this same transactionalism in contemporary Christian life?

1 SAMUEL 8

Read 1 Samuel 15 and 1 Samuel 13:11-14 together. In both moments, Saul disobeyed direct commands from God because he believed his own reasoning was better. What was Saul actually revealing about what he loved most—God himself, or something else?

- ↳ How do you respond when obedience to God costs you something you want? What does your response reveal about what you actually love?

1 SAMUEL 13:11-14; 1 SAMUEL 15

The sermon argues that trials—moments when the easy path is disobedience but you choose to follow God anyway—are the test that reveals whether faith is genuine. Why would trials be a more reliable indicator of real faith than spiritual experiences or good works?

1 PETER 1:6-7

Look at 1 Peter 1:6-7. Peter says trials are valuable because they 'prove that your faith is genuine.' What specific trial in your own life has forced you to choose between trusting God and getting what you wanted? What did that trial teach you about yourself?

- ↳ If you're not currently in a trial, what would it look like for you to actively trust God in an area where he's not giving you what you're asking for?

1 PETER 1:6-7

The sermon ends with Saul of Tarsus—a religious hypocrite who became Paul the apostle through grace. What does Paul's transformation tell us about the possibility of genuine conversion, even for those whose faith has been deeply transactional or false?

- ↳ Is there someone in your life whose faith seems hollow or self-serving? What would it mean to pray for them with the same hope that transformed Saul into Paul?

ACTS 9; 1 TIMOTHY 1:12-17

Daily Readings

The story of Saul teaches us that genuine faith is revealed not by spiritual experiences or good works, but by how we respond when God's will costs us what we want — a truth that runs from the Old Testament king through the apostle Paul, and into our own trials today.

Monday [1 Peter 1:6-7](#)

Peter writes that trials test the genuineness of our faith the way fire tests gold, proving its worth. Saul's life was marked by spiritual experiences and outward obedience, yet his faith crumbled the moment God required something he did not want to give. Our trials work the same way: they strip away every other reason to follow Jesus and leave only one question — do we love him for himself, or only for what he gives us?

Tuesday [Matthew 7:21-23](#)

Jesus warns that many will come to him saying 'Lord, Lord,' having even prophesied and cast out demons in his name, yet he will tell them he never knew them. Saul experienced the Spirit's power — he prophesied among the prophets, he was anointed king, he led Israel to victory — yet none of this saved him. A life full of religious activity and even supernatural signs proves nothing about the state of our hearts before God.

Wednesday [Hebrews 6:4-6](#)

The writer of Hebrews describes people who have been enlightened, tasted the heavenly gift, and shared in the Holy Spirit, yet fell away — impossibly difficult to renew to repentance. Saul had all these experiences. He had tasted God's power. He had done good works as judge and general. But his faith was always transactional: he loved God's provision, not God himself. When the provision stopped — when God refused his way — Saul's faith revealed itself as hollow.

Thursday [Acts 9](#)

The apostle Paul began as Saul of Tarsus, a man zealous for God's law, doing what he believed was God's work by persecuting the church — just as Old Testament Saul kept the forms of religious obedience while his heart remained transactional. But on the Damascus Road, Christ met him with grace that transformed him completely. If God can turn a religious hypocrite like Saul into a genuine lover of Jesus, there is hope for any of us whose faith is still tangled up with what we want rather than who God is.

Friday [1 Timothy 1:12-17](#)

Paul testifies that he was the foremost of sinners — a religious man who persecuted the church — yet received mercy because his encounter with Christ was real and transforming. Your trials are not punishment but God's invitation to discover whether your faith is genuine. And if you find yourself still clinging to religious forms while your heart pursues other things, Paul's testimony reminds you that grace can break through even the hardest religious exterior and make you new.

Memory Verse

In this you rejoice, though now for a little while, if necessary, you have been grieved by various trials, so that the tested genuineness of your faith—more precious than gold that perishes though it is tested by fire—may be found to result in praise and glory and honor at the revelation of Jesus Christ.

— 1 Peter 1:6-7

This passage crystallizes the sermon's central claim: trials are the God-appointed test that distinguishes genuine faith from religious pragmatism. Saul's life demonstrates what happens when faith is transactional; 1 Peter 1:6-7 shows that believers who endure trials prove the authenticity of their love for God himself, not merely his gifts.

Family Conversation

What Do We Love God For?

Saul kept asking God for things and obeying God when it got him what he wanted—but when God asked him to do something hard that didn't make sense, he refused. Think about a time this week when you had to do the right thing even though it was hard or you didn't get what you wanted. Did you do it? What made you decide?

WORKS FOR AGES 7+

For parents: This prompt invites your family to think about the difference between loving God himself versus loving what God gives us. The sermon showed how Saul used God to get what he wanted rather than loving God for who he is—and trials are what reveal the difference. Listen for where your kids naturally land, and be ready to share a time when you had to obey God even when it cost you something.

For Couples

Testing What We Love

When have you faced a trial where obedience cost you something you wanted — and what did that trial reveal about whether you love God himself or mainly his gifts?

Where in our marriage do we slip into using God transactionally — treating him as a means to get what we want rather than treasuring him for who he is — and how can we repent of that together?

What specific hardship is God currently using to test the genuineness of our faith, and how can we pray for one another to stay faithful in it, even if God doesn't give us the outcome we're hoping for?